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The Editors
Journal of Artificial Societies and Social Simulation

Dear Editors,

I submit "Activation and Foreclosure: Separating Screening from Exit Costs in Codified Moral Communities" for consideration at the *Journal of Artificial Societies and Social Simulation*.

Strictness in rule-governed communities is commonly understood to screen for committed members. Yet the same requirements also raise the cost of leaving. Observational evidence cannot separate selection from foreclosure because the structures that filter entrants also transform the outside options of those who remain. Simulation resolves this identification problem by manipulating screening conditions and exit capacity independently, an intervention that no observational design permits.

The model yields three findings. First, capture requires both an activated enforcement apparatus and foreclosed exit. With exit open, 0 of 1,890 runs reach capture despite an active rate of 0.598. The imposed-closure dose-response reaches 0.889 at closure 0.95, while the low-observability, low-reward cell remains at zero capture at every closure level. Second, approximately 84 percent of punishment concentration is manufactured by institutional privilege: the top five percent active share is 0.091 without the privilege bundle and 0.580 with it. Third, exit foreclosure arises through two routes: external imposition, or internal absorption and generational replacement.

The manuscript fits the journal as agent-based social simulation: it uses a controlled simulation experiment to separate two mechanisms that observational data confound, and its model description follows the ODD protocol. Religious communities are the empirical domain rather than the subject, and the mechanism is defined over structural properties rather than doctrinal content.

My appointment is in computational chemistry, and this manuscript is independent work in computational social science. The implementation is in Python, and the code and data are public at `https://github.com/khatvangi/code-geometry-abm`.

The manuscript is original, is not under consideration elsewhere, and has no competing interests or funding.

Sincerely,

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